

Beats PowerBeats Pro 2

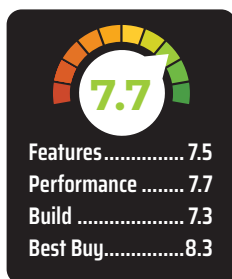
Ticks of all the boxes for the outdoor folk

Beats has long been known for its bass-heavy sound signature and stylish designs, appealing to both casual listeners and fitness enthusiasts. The original Powerbeats Pro gained popularity among athletes and gym-goers, thanks to their secure fit and punchy audio. Now, after six years, Beats has released the Powerbeats Pro 2, bringing several key upgrades to the table. With a more compact design, active noise cancellation, and heart-rate monitoring, are these the ultimate workout earbuds? To find out, we put the Powerbeats Pro 2 through their paces over the past week. Here's what we discovered.

BUILD AND DESIGN

The Powerbeats Pro 2 retain the signature ear-hook design that made the original a favourite among fitness enthusiasts. However, this time around, Beats has refined the ergonomics. The ear hooks are now 50% smaller and use a nickel-titanium alloy, making them both flexible and lightweight. In our testing, this led to a more comfortable fit over extended periods, with less pressure on the ears.

The earbuds themselves are 20% lighter, and the five included ear tip sizes ensure a snug seal for most users. That said, some testers at the Digit Test Centre found that achieving a perfect seal was tricky, impacting both noise cancellation



and bass response. The new wireless charging case is also 33% smaller, making it more pocket-friendly than its predecessor, though still larger than most competitors' cases. The build quality is solid, with an IPX4 rating for sweat and water resistance. While this should be fine for workouts, it's worth noting that other fitness-focused earbuds, such as the Jaybird Vista 2, offer higher durability ratings. The physical controls remain a highlight, with a tactile volume rocker and a multifunction "b" button on each bud for easy playback control.

FEATURES

For the first time, Beats has intro-

duced active noise cancellation (ANC) in the Powerbeats lineup. During our testing, the ANC was effective at reducing ambient gym noise and city traffic, though it didn't quite match the levels seen on the AirPods Pro 2. Transparency mode, however, worked well, offering a natural listening experience when awareness was needed.

A standout feature is the built-in heart-rate sensor, which uses optical LEDs to track your pulse. In our workouts, the readings were comparable to those of an Apple Watch, making this a useful addition for fitness tracking. However, if you already own an Apple Watch, its sensor takes precedence, meaning this feature may be redundant for some users.

Like other Apple-owned products, the Powerbeats Pro 2 are optimised for iOS, offering seamless pairing, Personalized Spatial Audio, and iCloud device switching. Android users can access most features via the Beats app, though they miss out on Apple-exclusive perks such as Audio Sharing and enhanced Find My functionality.

PERFORMANCE

Beats has tweaked the sound profile of the Powerbeats Pro 2, but the overall signature remains bass-heavy. The mids and highs are clear, but some testers noticed a slight emphasis in the 1.3kHz range, making certain vocals sound overly forward. The bass response is strong, though it lacks the depth and nuance found in premium audiophile earbuds. With ANC turned on, the soundstage felt slightly more immersive, but with it off, the earbuds sounded a bit thinner. In tracks like "Uptown Funk," the bass thump was pronounced and energetic, making these a solid choice for gym playlists. However, those looking for a more balanced sound may find the tuning a bit aggressive. Call quality was another highlight. The six-micro-